sentimental and cultural Sinophilia, a sympathetic attitude towards communism and an ambivalence about (if not active distrust of) the United States. These beliefs, in turn, informed Nehru's conception of his own and India's place in the global arena: as the self-appointed leader and spokesperson of Asia (and the Third World more broadly) against European imperial domination with a self-anointed obligation to mitigate conflict on the Asian continent, and as a big brother helping and guiding smaller brothers (i.e., the countries and leaders of Southeast Asia).[15]

To live up to this role, its (and Nehru's) culturally manifest destiny,[16] however, India lacked both the military might and the economic resources.[17] To make up for this shortfall, it relied on the stature and moral authority that Nehru had acquired through his self-sacrifice for the nationalist cause and his position as the first Prime Minister of independent and democratic India. The effectiveness of its diplomacy and its support of Southeast Asian nationalism was thus inextricably tied to Nehru's reputation and personal prestige, as well as the normative power of Nehruvian India's independence and its democratic credentials. In other words, the collective projection of a superior moral standing. Nehru's ideas, then, were as prescriptive as they were descriptive, perhaps even more prescriptive than descriptive.

Conversely, one of the major functions of Indian diplomacy then became the projection and protection of Nehru's image as the champion of the Third World and his self-declared role as the leader of Asian nationalism and anti-colonialism, since doing so allowed it to punch above its weight in global affairs and assume that it would play a significant role in Southeast Asia. This was a role that Nehru himself greatly prized, and refusal to acknowledge it, or even indifference towards it almost always produced a prickly reaction – as, for example, Nehru's reaction to the American invitation to Pakistani Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan for a state visit.[18] The demolition of this cherished role and the conceptual plumbing behind it was, in truth, the chief reason that made 1962 such a debilitating blow –